

STATE REVIEW LEARNINGS:

PHILANDER SMITH UNIVERSITY

UNDERGRADUATE

On-Site Review: January 22–23, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from both state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance resulted from multiple conversations with a group of stakeholders that included teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders & teachers, recent graduates, and DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," is based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

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Overall Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	MEETS

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	APPROACHING	BELOW
Recommendations		
Philander Smith University has a very small education preparation program. Recruiting additional candidates to increase overall enrollment, and particularly in subject shortage areas, will support the program's Standard 1 performance moving forward. Additionally, consider what additional supports those candidates may need to increase the 3-year completion rate. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 1.2b, Criteria 1.3a)</i>		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a	
Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (I.e.; Standards 1–3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	EPPs were not asked to submit formal plans to meet the state review framework targets or to show evidence of acting on their plans as part of the Spring 2024 review cycle. As a result, all EPPs in this cycle will receive a rating of MEETS.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Average Annual Growth	Performance Level
Three-year average annual growth	3%	19.5%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 1.2b Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of new enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	0%	BELOW

INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	30%	BELOW

Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
Recommendations		
Clinical experience is a strength at Philander Smith University. Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as teachers. This small university program leverages its relationships with schools to form strong partnerships and support their candidates as they prepare to become teachers. They should begin planning now to meet the state's one-year residency requirement that will apply to spring 2027 completers and beyond. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: - Audit coursework for classroom connections, ensuring that instructors provide models of instruction, incorporate high-quality instructional materials, clearly and intentionally familiarize candidates with 2023 Arkansas K-12 standards, and reflect with participants on the alignment between coursework and the classroom. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.1a Metrics 1 and 2, Criteria 2.1b Metric 3)</i> - Ensure candidates recognize the importance of applying methods to assess student work, including collecting data and showing evidence of impacting student growth. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.1a Metric 1, Criteria 2.3b Metric 2)</i>		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a	
Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based	
Performance Level	Explanation
APPROACHING	Overall, coursework incorporates some nationally recognized best practices around content instruction and somewhat familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Standards throughout licensure areas. As seen in the documentation provided, the program of study does employ nationally recognized best practices around content instruction. Through all four course observations, EDUC 203, Child Development, Teaching Literacy and Language Arts, and Educational Psychology, reviewers consistently observed instructors utilizing best practices such as modeling, small groups, questioning techniques, stating objectives, and checking for understanding. Lists of evidence-based practices are integrated into

	some coursework. However, aside from the program of study, most of the coursework submitted or observed does not consistently include nationally recognized best practices around content instruction, specifically related to the assessment of student understanding or learning (teacher use of rubrics, ratings, reports, etc.) Although some syllabi referenced high-quality instructional materials (HQIM) for students, they do not list any HQIM curriculum or how it is incorporated into the coursework. The reviewers did not observe teacher candidates incorporating the use of HQIM or evaluating the quality of instructional materials during course observations or in focus groups of course instructors and candidates. In the Partnership Focus Group, there was a Curriculum Associate for i-Ready who said they provide resources for candidates, but it was unclear how this support was included in the coursework. Coursework clearly familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K12 standards across multiple grade levels. Standards are consistently mentioned and aligned across coursework, assignments, and syllabi based on document review and the instructor focus group. However, there was no evidence presented of Arkansas K-12 standards being vertically aligned in coursework as a foundation for teacher development.
Criteria 2.1b Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher	
APPROACHING	Overall, candidates' coursework is sequenced and increases in rigor. Coursework incorporates Arkansas Educator competencies and Arkansas Teaching standards that develop candidates. Coursework is somewhat aligned with clinical experience. The Degree Audit and Course Grid of K-6 Bachelor of Science in Elementary Education clearly align coursework with intentional building of intensity and rigor around coursework and clinical experience. For example, during Freshman and Sophomore years, candidates take Core Skills for Educators, Foundations of Literacy, Intro to Math and Child Development, and Level 1 Field Experience. During Junior year, candidates will take Integrated curriculum, specific courses in teaching subjects like Teaching K-6 Math and Internship 1 (K-3). Finally, in their Senior year, candidates will take classes such as Teaching Diverse Learners, Teaching Disciplinary Literacy, and Exceptional Learners and choose from various Directed Teaching Seminars with their Internship II. Reinforcement opportunities are clearly articulated and planned for by design. Observations of coursework in ELED 373 included references to past courses and drawing comparisons across classes. Observations in the EDUC203 class included candidates taking the Educator Disposition Assessment that aligns with the ATS. Focus group participants in the Coursework Focus Group mentioned one instructor who meets with students and talks to them about scheduling and transcripts during advising days. All coursework specifically references and utilizes Arkansas Teaching Standards and Arkansas Educator Competencies. In one of the focus groups, Instructors mentioned that the Program was approved based on Competencies, and in one of the course observations, there were multiple references to the Competencies. According to Course Instructors, during the monthly faculty meetings, discussions revolve around what needs to be revised or added to coursework to ensure alignment. However, most coursework does not directly align with clinical experience. Courses and assignments, even those taught concurrently with clinical experiences in the same semester, such as ELED 333, ELED463, and EDUC303, ask students to create fictional plans or experiences and do not ask them to reference their own experience observing internship or direct teaching. Only one course from the evidence submitted, Teaching Exceptional Learners, has a direct connection where candidates observe a student with a disability for at least 10 hours as part of a case study assignment.
Criteria 2.1c Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors	

APPROACHING	Course instructors are knowledgeable and effective and provide strong feedback and support to candidates. However, although Arkansas K-12 standards are cited often in syllabi, the way that the course instructors designed and facilitated course content and assignments, based upon documentation submitted and observation of EDUC203, do not fully demonstrate the instructor's knowledge of the new, 2023 Arkansas K-12 Standards and new ATLAS assessments, as both have recently changed. All course instructors hold an AR state licensure and receive Professional Development. It is unclear how often this PD occurs and what the general requirements around professional learning and demonstration of their content knowledge are apart from licensure requirements. All the professors have experience in education, and all the teaching candidates in the Focus Group agreed that they value their professors speaking from experience. All six course instructors in the focus group discussed providing feedback and support to candidates. Focus groups with candidates supported these statements. All five candidates feel their professors are knowledgeable. Across several coursework observations, instructors modeled effective teaching practices, such as providing feedback on extended response questions and conducting an interactive read-aloud. They also used their educator experiences to answer questions about handling specific classroom scenarios. In one observation, the instructor strongly facilitated questioning and discussion in various small groups and individual reflections. The instructor provided high-quality feedback in response to students' incorrect responses, added additional information, or challenged their thinking.
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INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Indicator 2.2a Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as teachers. The overall sequence of clinical experiences intentionally builds off previous experiences. For example, Level I Field, taken during the spring of their sophomore year, is mainly observation, and Level II Field includes their internships 1 and 2. Level III is their directed teaching and is taken in the spring of their Senior year. The experiences are well-sequenced and gradually built throughout training, and placements reflect the subject and grade level of the license being sought. Directed teaching incorporates K-3 and 4-6 grades. In the documentation provided, it states that candidates have a gradual release in their development opportunities, moving from theory to practice and from being under the supervision of a college supervisor to the supervision of a cooperating teacher. Candidates and course instructors confirmed this gradual release in their respective focus groups. The overall variety of experiences provides adequate opportunities for candidates to work with students with varied learning needs. Students discussed working with students with autism, dyslexia, ADHD, IEPs, Sped, and TESOL. Philander Smith partners with three public school districts and one charter school, providing candidates with different clinical experience options.

Criteria 2.2b

Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

MEETS

Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship.

Most experienced mentor teachers are equipped and demonstrate that they have the coaching skills to support and develop a teaching candidate. The Directed Teachers Handbook outlines a process to select mentor teachers based on criteria that include years of experience, demonstrated effectiveness, and pedagogical knowledge. In the Focus Group, both mentor teachers reported that their principals had asked them to be mentors. They cited having demonstrated effectiveness by mentoring multiple interns over the years. Each mentor teacher had at least three years of teaching in the classroom. However, no evidence was provided of a formal evaluation system to determine the effectiveness of the mentors.

EPP and district leaders collaborate during at least one meeting before the candidates' assignment to a mentor teacher. Participants in the Focus Group with EPP Partners said some districts have processes to train and monitor mentor teachers; others do not.

Most program clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. In the focus group, the candidates cited them using different modes of communication, checking lesson plans, observing 1-2 times a week, analyzing videos, modeling, self-reflection and aligning standards in the lesson plan, debriefing, pop-ins, and relationship building.

In the candidate observation, the clinical supervisor used the TESS rubric language throughout the session to provide feedback and have the teaching candidate reflect on rubric components for professional growth. Note that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by the 2024-25 academic year by all EPPs. Prior to that time, EPPs may use the TESS framework or another aligned tool.

Most clinical supervisors have a proven history and show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. In the documentation submitted, there were multiple examples of strong written feedback to candidates. Emails from course instructors, written feedback in observation rubrics, and at least three observations per internship from the clinical supervisor. Also, the candidate we observed received high-quality oral and written feedback during her post-conference. For example, the clinical supervisor gave clear feedback - timely and specific, established goals for the next observation, aligned to student work on prefixes, acknowledged the teacher's checks for understanding with whiteboards, call, and response, called on students, using thumbs up, and walking around the room. The feedback was tied to future planning. They were working on goals from TESS. They reviewed the rubric together, discussed specific examples from the lesson, and problem-solved individual challenges.

In the Candidate focus group, they said Interns receive written feedback a minimum of four times (three are formal) from their clinical supervisor and mentor during their internship.

Criteria 2.2c

Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

APPROACHING

There are some collaborative processes in place with districts and schools to co-construct the clinical internship for candidates. The candidates, the three mentor teachers, and three principals from the Partnership Focus Group spoke about strong collaboration with clinical supervisors.

In the Partner Focus Group, there were three principals, a superintendent, and a Curriculum Associate for i-Ready. The three principals talked about their relationship with Philander Smith University. They talked about strong, long-lasting relationships

	with clear, open communication channels. All three principals discussed how they could call Dr. Smith and Dr. Sain at Philander Smith with any issues. However, no evidence was submitted of structures or processes in place to support the continued development of clinical supervisors.
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INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a Candidates are successful with their program coursework	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	There are clear systems in place that evidence, feedback, and support are given to teachers, including the Unit Assessment System, PSC Lesson and Classroom Assessment Rubric, and Cooperating Teacher Observation Form. Evidence submitted showed candidate proficiency with coursework over the past three cohorts. The candidates exceeded the 3.0 GPA requirement, earned a C or better in their two student teaching experiences (DST Primary and DST Intermediate), and successfully passed their Multiple Subject Praxis Assessments to earn their teaching license. These three data points suggest that the candidates are mastering their coursework and goals within the clinical experiences. Due to the small program, there is an informal but individualized way of supporting students. In one focus group, Instructors talked about being proactive when they notice a candidate falling behind. They will email other course instructors and the Chair, who will personally contact the student. Candidates in another focus group supported this. In one observed course, EDUC 353, candidates were reminded to share notes on a platform for others who were absent. In another class, EDUC 343, the professor provided feedback during brainstorming and follow-up slides after a student report. The documentation submitted showed evidence of tutoring sessions available for students.
Criteria 2.3b Candidates are successful in their clinical internship	
APPROACHING	Evidence suggests that candidates are somewhat successful in their clinical internships. Evidence submitted shows all the candidates in the last three cohorts earning a C or better in their two student teaching experiences. This shows that the candidates successfully set their goals within the clinical experiences. The TESS Intensive Support Growth Plan provides evidence of individualized support plans for off-track students, although there was no evidence submitted that students are involved in the process. There was little to no evidence submitted that candidates have the capacity to impact student growth. There was no evidence of assessments of student work, student understanding or learning (teacher use of rubrics, ratings, reports, etc.) Candidates showed proficiency in effective teaching skills as measured by TESS scores. Out of 6 students, 84% were effective or above. The TESS Intensive Support Growth Plan provides evidence of individualized support plans for students who are off-track; however, there was little to no evidence that candidates receive feedback and opportunities to encourage their retention.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
EXCEEDS	EXCEEDS	APPROACHING
Recommendations		
Philander Smith University does an outstanding job ensuring that its program completers become licensed teachers in Arkansas public schools and districts, and that they stay in the classroom for multiple years. Although the number of respondents is very small, recommendations include: - Addressing the concerns of candidates who do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3b</i>) - Ensure that program completers have the capacity to impact student growth and can demonstrate that capacity in the classroom. (<i>Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3c</i>)		

INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license	76%	100%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.1b A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	n/a	n/a	

Criteria 3.1c A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try			
Metric	Target	EPP's First Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	65%	88%	EXCEEDS

INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	62%	100%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.2b A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	38%	100%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.2c Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.6	2.67	EXCEEDS

INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by DESE	81%	100%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3b Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by DESE	75%	33%	BELOW
Criteria 3.3c A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	0%	BELOW